

PROCESSORS

The processor landscape changes more frequently than the seasons. Every few months, the megahertz war reaches a culmination and begets a new breed of processors to be born of AMD and Intel. With each family of processors, these chips feature lower power consumption and heat dissipation for greater reliability and lower operating costs. Also, as processors advance at a frantic pace, other system components sprint to keep up with them, resulting in a healthy situation where you have faster overall systems.

The power trip

When choosing a processor, the most important factor is its application. Once you've defined your application area, look at suitable specifications such as the processor speed, the brand and other factors such as the L1 and L2 cache, fabrication process, etc.

If your needs centre on non-intensive tasks such as word processing, surfing and e-mail, then your processing requirements will be satisfied by a 1 GHz-class processor. However, if you like to live on the cutting-edge with 3D games and 3D rendering and multimedia authoring software, then you will need a processor with enough horse power to efficiently run these applications.

The cache on the processor is crucial in applications such as image-editing and gaming, where there are repetitive routines and frequent access of data sets.

Newer processors have moved to the 0.13 micron fabrication process. When considering such a processor,

Nominees		
Name	Contacts	Comments
Intel Pentium 4 2.8 GHz	Nebula Technologies Pvt Ltd, Ph: 022-2673 0567	Reaching still higher with faster speeds and with support for 100 MHz bus, this processor is highly suited to processor-intensive applications.
Intel Pentium 2.53 GHz	Nebula Technologies Pvt Ltd, Ph: 022-2673 0567	Based on a 0.13 micron core, this processor delivers brilliant performance without drawing on too much power.

ensure it is supported by the motherboard as well. If you choose an Intel Pentium 4 or an Athlon XP, it is important to choose supporting components such that they complement the processor and do not slow it down. Therefore, if you are looking for pure performance in, say, a 2.8 GHz Pentium 4 processor, pair it with an RDRAM-based system and a fast hard drive. Similarly, pair up an Athlon XP processor with the fastest RAM you can afford, along with a complementary motherboard.

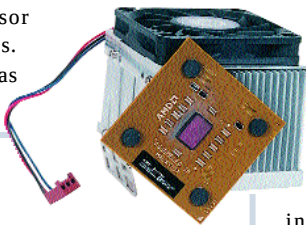
And the award goes to...

The processor that wins kudos as the fastest one as per our laboratory tests this year turned is the AMD Athlon XP. With the 0.13 micron technology, the processor is ideally suited to applications that involve streaming data such as audio and video encoding.



AMD Athlon 2600+
AMD Far East Ltd,
Ph: 011-6238620

The verdict: Armed with six processing units and a high clock speed, this processor turned out to be the best overall performer across applications



3D AUTHORIZING TOOLS

3ds max 5

The 3D rendering application that scaled new levels of utility and enhancement, 3ds max 5 is a bubbling cauldron of functionalities, ranging from the interface, modelling, rendering, animation and special effects features. In the interface, the menus have been re-ordered such that similar tasks are grouped in more logical and intuitive task groups for easier access. Tools such as the Dope Sheet make it easier to change animation characteristics, without worrying about the animation curve, while the Bones tool greatly simplifies skeletal animation. When used in conjunction with the IK Spline solver, the connected elements in complex models move much more realistically and far greater control has been affected over them. In tasks such as realistic lip-synching, the Progressive Modifier gives animators control over the morphing stages in steps, providing a much smoother and

realistic effect. Once a separate package, Reactor is now bundled with 3ds max 5 and allows you to add dynamic properties to objects such as water droplets, explosions, smoke, etc. The Toon Shader function provides far smoother control over the colours and textures in cartoon animation.

With a plethora of added functionality and a far greater control over complex tasks, 3ds max 5 provides an unbeatable package for 3D animators and modellers.



3ds max 5
Discreet,
Ph: 022-26952000

The verdict: With an array of features such as advanced animation controls, environment effects, improved menu layout, 3ds max 5 bags top honours for 3D animation applications

